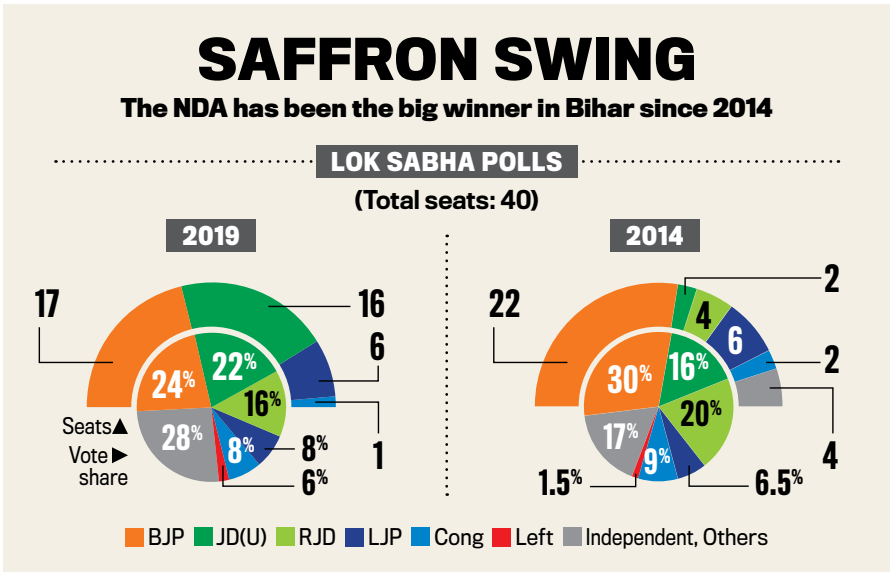




ANI

habits to ridiculing Lalu for his many children to the Opposition going after people's gold and mangalsutras, it was soon clear that no topic is off the table this poll season.

The Challenger

Just before he winds up his speech in Hajipur on April 29, Tejashwi pauses significantly. "*Chup chaap*...," he chants, and the crowd boisterously fills in the rest, "*Lalten chhaap* (Quietly, press the lantern sign)". This is not just a slogan but a subtle message as well. Tejashwi's intentions are clear: he seeks to rally support for the RJD while eschewing any overly assertive behaviour, a stereotype often associated with his caste cohort, the Yadavs.

Tejashwi's companion on the campaign trail these days is often Mukesh Sahani, chief of the Vikassheel Insaan Party (VIP), a recent partner in the *mahagathbandhan*. Sahani opens the meetings, where he never fails to remind the audience how the BJP poached his three MLAs. Tejashwi picks up the thread, saying the BJP had not just taken away their MLAs, but also "hijacked" their "*chachaji*" (Nitish Kumar).

In a strategic move, Tejashwi avoids directly criticising the CM in public speeches, despite the latter's vehement attacks on his family. Instead, the RJD chief often says, "*Jahan rahein, swasth rahein* (Wherever he is, he should stay healthy)," while referring to him, in an evident effort to garner sympathy from the communities that back Nitish.

At his meticulous campaign meetings, Tejashwi has revealed a leadership persona that has taken everyone by surprise. From his shrewd mimicry of Modi's folksy "*Bhaiyoo-behno*" colloquialism in Vaishali to his rapport with the crowd in Khagaria, where he prompted them to reflect on the changes wrought during Modi's decade-long tenure, Tejashwi has displayed an uncanny ability to connect with his constituents.

At rallies, he mocks the PM and lists the scores of unrealised promises from the BJP's 2014 and 2019 campaigns. Often, he even serenades the crowd with a brief ditty or a verse from the film song, '*Jeena yahaan, marna yahaan*', to underscore his commitment to the Bihar cause. The state's youthful electorate, especially the 18-29 age group that comprises over 20 per cent of the voters, seem to hang on to his every word. Hundreds of them can be seen recording Tejashwi's speeches on their mobile phones. On May 1, Tejashwi took to the social media platform X to share a video clip from a public meeting where he's seen playing recordings of Modi's past speeches, the intention behind to highlight the "*jhumlas*". The RJD has also unveiled a campaign song, 'Apna Tejashwi', which is also gaining traction.

Tejashwi's annus mirabilis was 2020 and the main event the Bihar assembly polls where he led the RJD alliance against the Janata Dal (United)-BJP combine and emerged as the single largest party with 75 MLAs (in the 243-seat house). He burnished that image when he served as deputy CM for 17 months from August 2022, after Nitish returned to the *mahagathbandhan*. From conducting late-night inspections at hospitals to generating some 500,000 government jobs, Tejashwi's reputation grew in the one and a half years he was in the job. Nitish may now brush aside his ex-deputy's